can only make terrifying the idea that it, too, will now possess the ultimate weapon. Yet the real worry with North Korea becoming a nuclear power is one the headlines, and US officials, have so far ignored.

From new negotiations to war planning, the American foreign policy community is approaching North Korea as it has for the past quarter century, as a problem to be solved. Yet assuming Donald Trump (and his successors) and Kim Jong-un neither achieve denuclearization nor blunder into war, the real question is whether Kim will respect the power of his nukes enough to make sure they are safe and safely controlled. In other words, the world needs to worry less about the risk of a North Korean nuclear war than a nuclear accident. Soon enough, Kim will learn that it's not easy being a nuclear power. All he has to do is ask the Americans or the Russians.

On the evening of September 18, 1980, at the height of the Cold War, an overworked and exhausted US Air Force technician dropped an eight-pound socket eighty feet down the silo of a Titan II intercontinental ballistic missile (ICBM) in Damascus, Arkansas. The socket pierced the thin aluminum skin of the missile, releasing a jet of highly flammable missile fuel. The crew had no way of stopping the leaking fuel. Nine hours later, before an air force major crisis response team could reach the site, the missile exploded. The 740-ton concrete and steel silo door was blown off by the explosion, and the nuclear warhead itself was hurled dozens of meters beyond the silo complex. Only the warhead's safety mechanisms prevented a nine-megaton detonation barely fifty miles from Little Rock, where then US vice president Walter Mondale happened to be visiting. This accident, while one of the most potentially devastating in the history of the US nuclear operations, is just one of dozens that have occurred since America and Russia began their nuclear arms race nearly three-quarters of a century ago.

That the world has not experienced a nuclear detonation since Nagasaki, other than planned tests, or suffered a civilian catastrophe due to a military accident is due not only to the extraordinary seriousness with which the nuclear powers took their responsibilities but also to luck during potential crises. Betting on whether the world will